

Combine animal and plant protein foods in daily diet

When we think of protein foods, what usually come to mind are chicken, egg, fish, and meat. Many of us primarily consume animal protein foods daily. But, have you ever heard of plant protein? Some may not be aware that foods like tempeh, tofu, beans, legumes are also rich in protein—they're plant-based protein sources! Did you know that combining animal and plant protein foods gives a more nutritious diet?

Why is protein important for your body?

Protein is needed in the forming of new cells and repairing of old cells in our body. It is involved in the growth and maintenance of the human body. It is also important in the formation of enzymes and hormones.

Recommendations of daily protein intake

According to the Malaysian Dietary Guidelines 2020:



Fish:
1 serving



Poultry/meat/eggs:
1-2 servings



Legumes:
1 serving

Know your sources of protein

Animal Protein

Fish and shellfish

- Good sources of protein, contain less saturated fat than meat and poultry
- **Fish:** salmon & herring - high in omega-3-fatty acid
- **Shellfish:** crabs, lobster, oysters, shrimps - low in saturated fat & low in calories



Meat and poultry

- Complete protein, containing all essential amino acids
- e.g. chicken or turkey breast, beef or pork tenderloin



Eggs

- Complete protein, containing all essential amino acids
- **Egg yolk:** a rich source of many vitamins and minerals



Plant Protein

Legumes

- Low in fat (e.g. soya beans, red beans, chickpeas, green beans), high in dietary fibre, free from saturated fats & no cholesterol
- Contain phytonutrients



Nuts

- Contain unsaturated fatty acids & phytonutrients
- e.g. walnuts, pine nuts, almonds



Soya bean foods

- Rich in protein, dietary fibre, unsaturated fat, vitamins & minerals
- e.g. tofu, soya bean milk, soya bean curd, tempeh



Ideas to combine animal and plant proteins into your meal



Breakfast

Soya bean milk with wholegrain egg sandwich



Lunch

Add chickpeas to beef stew



Dinner

Stir-fry shrimp with tofu

Tips to cooking and consuming protein foods

The ways you cook and consume protein foods are very important in order for your body to get all the essential nutrients needed and avoiding any excessive intake:



Use healthier cooking methods such as steaming, stewing, braising, boiling, poaching, microwaving, grilling, roasting and air frying

Limit deep-frying methods as deep-frying adds fat and calories to these dishes



Limit breading and battering as these will cause the food to soak up more oil during frying, therefore, adding more fat and calories

Choose lean cuts of meat and poultry to minimise the intake of saturated fat



Choose skinless chicken parts before cooking

Limit the intake of organ meats such as liver and kidney



Consume nuts in small amounts (on a weekly basis) because they are high in calories

Try this recipe with both plant-based and animal proteins!

Braised beancurd



Ingredients

350 g (2 pcs) soft beancurd, cut into 12 pieces (square)
100 g prawn, remove shell
60 g (3 tbsp) canned peas
50 g (1/2) carrot, cut into small pieces
10 g (2 pips) garlic
10 g (1 tbsp) vegetable oil
2 g pepper
5 g (2 tsp) cornflour, mixed with 4 tbsp water
salt to taste
500 ml (2 cups) water

Garnishing

Coriander leaves and spring onion

Method

1. Heat oil and fry garlic until golden brown.
2. Add in prawns and stir-fry for a while.
3. Add in water, carrot and allow to simmer until half cooked.
4. Add in peas, beancurd, salt and cornflour mixture. Stir.
5. To serve, sprinkle pepper and garnish with spring onion and coriander leaves.